Data Analysis
Gaelic DP Structure

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December 8, 2025

1 Basics

What is the order of nouns and adjectives in Gaelic? Is there an order between adjectives? How does it compare with English? What might this suggest about the structures in the two languages?

(1) cù mòr brèagha dubh albanach
dog big beautiful black scottish
' A beautiful big black Scottish dog.'

(2) *cù dubh mòr brèagha albanach
dog black big beautiful scottish
' A beautiful big black Scottish dog.'

Now consider the order of APs and PPs in the language. What is the generalization? How might you draw a structure for this? Compare with English, or another language you know. What are the differences?

(3) an dealbh mòr breagha de Mhàiri
the picture big beautiful of Mairi
'The big beautiful picture of Mairi'

(4) * an dealbh de Mhàiri mòr breagha
the picture of Mairi big beautiful
'The big beautiful picture of Mairi'

(5) an dealbh mòr breagha aig Màiri
the picture big beautiful at Mairi
'Mairi's big beautiful picture'

(6) * an dealbh aig Màiri mòr breagha
the picture at Mairi big beautiful
'Mairi's big beautiful picture'

Finally, compare what happens with multiple PPs. Do they have the same restrictions as multiple APs?

(7) an dealbh mòr aig Seumas de Mhàiri
the picture big at Seumas of Mairi
'Seumas' big picture of Mairi'

(8) an dealbh mòr de Mhàiri aig Seumas
the picture big of Mairi at Seumas
'Seumas' big picture of Mairi'

2 Numerals

Consider the position of numerals. Where do these occur? How does that compare with English or other languages?

(9) (na) còig dealbhan mòra de Mhàiri
(the.P) five picture.P big.P of Màiri
'(The) five big pictures of Mairi.'

(10) (na) dealbhan (*còig) mòra (*còig) de Mhàiri (*còig)
(the.P) picture.P big.P of Màiri
'(The) five big pictures of Mairi.'

Now look at the following coordination data. What does it suggest about the relative hierarchical structure between PPs and prenominal elements in the language:

(11) Cheannaich e [dealbh mòr] agus [ìomhaigh bheag] de Mhàiri
Buy.PAST he picture big and image small of Mairi
'He bought a big picture and a small image of Mairi.'

(12) Cheannaich e [còig dealbhan mòra] agus [trì iomhaighean beaga] de Mhàiri
Buy.PAST he five pictures big and three images small of Mairi
'He bought five big pictures and three small images of Mairi.'

(13) Cheannaich e [na còig dealbhan mòra] agus [na trì iomhaighean beaga] de Mhàiri
Buy.PAST he the.P five pictures big and the.P three images small of Mairi
'He bought five big pictures and three small images of Mairi.'

Draw a tree structure which captures where everything is. Do you need any movement operations? Is there a way of maintaining the idea that there is some shared structure in the Gaelic and English nominal?

3 More postnominal elements

Now we turn to demonstratives. Look at the following and state a hypothesis as to whether demonstratives are higher than or lower than the position of articles:

(14) na dealbhan snog ud
the pictures nice that
'Those nice pictures'

(15) a. dealbhan snog
pictures nice
'nice pictures'

b. *dealbhan snog ud
pictures nice that
'Those nice pictures'

(16) a. na daoine sin
the people that
'those people'

b. iad sin
they that
'those (guys)'

c. Daibhidh ud
David that
'That David'

Does the following co-ordination data support or undermine that claim?

(17) a. na dealbhan agus na h-ìomhaighean sin
the pictures and the images that
'Those pictures and images'

b. * na dealbhan agus ìomhaighean sin
the pictures and images that
'Those pictures and images'

(18) na dealbhan agus *(na h-)ìomhaighean
the pictures and images
'the pictures and images'

What does the following suggest about the position of the demonstrative and the PP possessor:

(19) na dealbhan mòra ud aig Màiri
the pictures big that at Mairi
'Those big pictures of Mary's.'

(20) * na dealbhan mòra aig Màiri ud
the pictures big at Mairi that
for: 'Those big pictures of Mary's.'

What does the following suggest about the position of the demonstrative and the PP complement and does this comport with any ideas you've already had about PP possessors and complements?

(21) na dealbhan mòra ud de Mhàiri
the pictures big that of Mairi
'those big pictures of Mary.'

(22) * na dealbhan mòra de Mhàiri ud
the pictures big of Mairi that
'those big pictures of Mary.'

Now consider the following data with the quantifier *uile*, meaning "all". Where do you think it occurs?

(23) na dealbhan snog sin uile (*sin)
the pictures nice that all (*that)
'All those nice pictures'

(24) na dealbhan mòra ud uile de Mhàiri
the pictures big that all of Mairi
'All those big pictures of Mary.'

(25) * na dealbhan mòra ud de Mhàiri uile
the pictures big that of Mairi all
'All those big pictures of Mary.'

4 Genitives

An alternative means of expressing possession, not involving a PP, involves a genitive marked DP. Compare the position of this genitive to that of the PPs and APs.

(26) dealbh mòr Sheumais
picture big Seumas.GEN
'Seumas' big picture'

(27) * dealbh Sheumais mòr
picture Seumas.GEN big
'Seumas' big picture'

(28) dealbh mòr Sheumais de Mhàiri
picture big Seumas.GEN of Mairi
'Seumas' big picture of Mairi'

(29) * dealbh mòr de Mhàiri Sheumais
picture big of Mairi Seumas.GEN
'Seumas' big picture of Mairi'

The next set of data need a set-up argument where we first establish a constraint on the syntax of reciprocals like 'each other'. What do the following suggest that constraint is (hint: think reflexives):

(30) Bhuail na caileagan a cheile
hit.PAST the girls each other
'The girls hit each other.'

(31) * Bhuail a cheile na caileagan
hit.PAST each other the girls

(32) * Bhuail athair nan caileagan a cheile
hit.PAST father the.GEN.PL girls each other
'The girls' father hit each other.'

With this in hand, consider the following structures and work out whether they support your structures so far:

(33) dealbhan nan caileagan de a cheile
pictures the.GEN.PL girls of each other
'the girls pictures of each other.'

(34) * dealbhan a cheile dhe na caileagan
pictures each other of the.PL girls
'Each other's pictures of the girls.'

(35) * dealbhan athair a cheile dhe na caileagan
pictures father each other of the.PL girls
'Each other's father's pictures of the girls.'

Now we run the same type of argument looking at the meanings of pronouns and quantifiers. What does the following suggest? Is it in line with your current hypothesis?

(36) Cheannaich gach gille dealbh de a mhàthair
buy.PAST every boy picture of his mother
'Every boy bought a picture of his mother.' (different mother for each boy)

(37) Cheannaich a mhàthair dealbh de gach gille
buy.PAST his mother picture of every boy
'His mother bought a picture of every boy.' (only one mother)

(38) Cheannaich caraid a mhàthar dealbh de gach gille
buy.PAST friend his mother.GEN picture of every boy
'His mother's friend bought a picture of every boy.' (only one mother)

(39) dealbh gach gille de a mhàthair
picture every boy.GEN of his mother
'Every boy's picture of his mother.' (different mother for each boy)

(40) dealbh a mhàthar de gach gille
picture his mother.GEN of every boy
'His mother's picture of every boy.' (only one mother)

(41) dealbh caraid a mhàthar de gach gille
picture friend his mother.GEN of every boy
'His mother's friend's picture of every boy.' (only one mother)

State a generalization about the relationship between a genitive and a definite article on the basis of the following:

(42) * an dealbh mòr Sheumais
the picture big Seumas.GEN
for: 'Seumas' big picture'

State a generalization about the relationship between a *possessive* PP and a definite article on the basis of the following:

(43) * dealbh mòr breagha aig Màiri
picture big beautiful at Mairi
for: 'Mairi's big beautiful picture'

5 Some syntax-semantics arguments

What does the meaning of the following phrase suggest about the position of *eile*, "other" with respect to adjectives? Can you make an assumption that seems reasonable and will support a particular structure (hint: think c-command)?

(44) an dealbh mòr eile de Mhàiri
the picture big other of Mairi
'The other big picture of Mary.'/'*The big other picture of Mairi' (meaning: there are two big pictures of Mari).

What does the following sentence say about the relative position of the genitive DP and *eile*? Is it consistent with your current hypothesis?

(45) dealbhan mòra Sheumais eile de Mhàiri
pictures big.PL Seumas.GEN other of Màiri
'Seumass other big pictures of Màiri.'

Finally draw a structure or structures that explains as many of the generalizations as possible.